



Full Length Article

Exploratory Study of Public Relations Roles in Zimbabwe

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ABSTRACT

This exploratory study examined the practice of public relations in Zimbabwe by surveying and understanding public relations roles typically practiced by Zimbabwean PR practitioners. Through the lens of systems theory, the research investigated whether the practiced public relations roles allow organizations to perform all three boundary spanning functions such as output, throughput, and input. The results confirmed prior theoretically and empirically derived typology of roles (technician, manager, strategist) from the African continent. However, the observed structures of public relations roles deviate from previous findings, indicating that Zimbabwean PR practitioners' professional roles may differ from those in neighboring countries.

1. Introduction

Amplified cultural, economic, and professional globalization has re-introduced the concept of public relations roles into the scholarly agenda, as research on international public relations roles becomes a necessary and crucial function in further understanding the practice of public relations in different countries (Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011). Increasingly, scholars have called for and offered more culturally diverse public relations research. Creedon and Al-Khaja (2019) highlighted the need "to move the discipline's scholarship from global isolation to cultural inclusivity" (p. 84) through broadening research outreach. This exploratory study looks at the practice of public relations in Zimbabwe, an understudied African country with an active public relations industry and a long history of the profession. Specifically, the current study contributes to the ongoing discussion about whether the structure and performance of public relations roles differ across national and cultural borders and how it defines the profession globally (Vercic, Grunig, & Grunig, 1996).

Previous research showed that Zimbabwe has had an active chapter of the International Public Relations Association (IPRA) and its own Institute of Public Relations since 1966 and has PR practitioners working in several sectors (Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018). Yet, its inclusion in public relations studies is lacking (Ngondo, 2019). In fact, of the 54 African countries, only a handful of nations have been studied in connection with public relations: Kenya (e.g., Kiambi & Nadler, 2012); South Africa (e.g., Holtzhausen, Petersen, & Tindall, 2003; Holtzhausen, 2005; Rensburg & Botha, 2014; Tindall & Holtzhausen, 2011); Nigeria (e.g.,

Molleda & Alhassan, 2006; Ukonu, Anyadike, & Okoro, 2018); Ghana (e.g., Wu & Baah-Boakye, 2009, 2014); Uganda, Mauritius, Guinea, and Tanzania (Van Heerden & Rensburg, 2005), and most recently Zimbabwe (Muchena, 2017, 2018; Ngondo, 2019; Oksiutycz & Nhedzi, 2018, among others).

This study widens the research coverage of the African continent by surveying Zimbabwean PR practitioners to explore their professional roles and understanding of public relations. Further, this study contributes to the recognition of cultural diversity in the practice and theory of public relations, as urged by Dutta and Elers (2020). Similar to Azionya, Oksiutycz, and Benecke (2019), who asserted that their research offered a new way of representing marginalized voices in public relations education and industry, this current research follows suit. First, it extends and clarifies previous work on public relations roles in Africa by Steyn (1999), Tindall and Holtzhausen (2011), and Van Heerden and Rensburg (2005), whose research included participants from countries such as Uganda, Nigeria, Kenya, South Africa, Mauritius, Guinea, and Tanzania. In so doing, it confirms previous theoretically and empirically derived typology of roles, yet observes a variation in the structure of those roles in comparison to the earlier findings on the African continent. Second, the study offers a unique insight into the public relations activities and the composition of the public relations labor force in Zimbabwe and adds to the kaleidoscope of understandings of global public relations with its specific focus on Zimbabwe.

In what follows, the manuscript briefly discusses public relations research conducted in Africa, provides background on the public relations practice and education, and gives an overview of public relations

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